



Le Boucher

Director: Claude Chabrol

Production Companies: Les Films la Boétie,
Euro International Films

Producer: André Génovès

Production Manager: Fred Surin

Administration: Bernard Marsault, Gérard Espinet

Assistant Directors: Pierre Gaucher, Michel Dupuy

Script Supervisor: Aurore Paquiss

Scenario/Dialogue: Claude Chabrol

Director of Photography: Jean Rabier

Camera Operator: Claude Zidi

Editor: Jacques Gaillard

Art Director: Guy Littaye

Costume Designer: Joseph Poulard

Make-up: Louis Bonnemaison

Hair: Renée Guidet

Music: Pierre Jansen

Sound: Guy Chichignoud

Sound Re-recording: Alex Prout

Cast:

Stéphane Audran (*Hélène Marcoux*)

Jean Yanne (*Popaul Thomas*)

Antonio Passalia (*Angelo*)

Roger Rudel (*Grumbach*)

Mario Beccaria (*Léon Hamel*)

William Guerault (*Charles*)

Pasquale Ferone (*Father Charpy*)

France-Italy 1970

92 mins

Digital (restoration)

The screening on Wed 9 Sep will be introduced by
season curator Catherine Wheatley

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Claude Chabrol: Elements of Crime

Le Boucher

SPOILER WARNING The following notes give away some of the plot.

Around the midpoint of Claude Chabrol's *Le Boucher* a schoolteacher, Mlle Hélène (Stéphane Audran), is conducting a party of her pupils through the caves of the Dordogne. Though Cro-Magnon Man who inhabited them was, by comparison, a primitive beast, she reminds them, it is to his ability to survive that they owe their existence. The irony of the film is that Mlle Hélène fails to note the implications of her own wise counsel: that we must embrace the beast in us or die.

Chabrol, as always, is concerned with the ways in which the primitive erupts through the conventional; in this case, in crimes of passion which tear apart the social fabric. He distinguishes two contrary forces in that passion. The primordial instinct to love or possess, which preserves the race, and which connects Cro-Magnon Man and the schoolchildren, is, when frustrated, the same instinct which will destroy it. It is not accidental that there stands in the village square of Trémolat, outside the quiet school building where Mlle Hélène lives and teaches, a huge war memorial guarded by chains and marked off at each corner by a gunshell. In the same way the village butcher, Popaul (Jean Yanne), rebuffed politely in love by Mlle Hélène, keeps vigil outside her window at night, a menacing sentinel.

What do we mean 'embrace the beast'? Chabrol warns of the power of the instinct for survival and of the curious forms it takes. There is little retreat from it possible even in the most sophisticated societies. It is the force which provokes the urbane husband of *La Femme infidèle* to strike down his wife's lover; the same force drives her to hide his guilt in order to preserve her family. It is the possessive force which twists the restless triangle of *Les Biches* until one of the three is expelled by murder. It is the force which persuades Charles Duchaussoy in *Que la bête meure* to give up love for the satisfaction of avenging his slaughtered son, and once he has realised that the beast is in all of us, to give up life too.

Mlle Hélène of course, in her own cool way, is as desperately concerned to survive as anyone. She takes no lovers, despite her affection for the butcher, since she has had an unhappy affair ten years ago. Now she has retired to the country, and her school and her pupils are her family. In this partial way she serves tradition and continuity, and provides her own weak link in the chain from Cro-Magnon Man. On her own, she practises yoga. It is, as far as Chabrol is concerned, a retreat as destructive as the crimes of passion it provokes. At a quiet woodland picnic, Mlle Hélène sweetly but firmly turns down Popaul's tentative offer to kiss her. 'I would say nothing but I ask you not to do it.' At a later picnic on the steep banks overlooking the Dordogne, blood drips arrestingly on to a pupil's sandwich. The victim's hand projects over the cliff edge above their heads. Someone has begun to murder the village girls, cutting them up outrageously with a knife. The next victim is the young bride whose wedding we attended at the beginning of the film, a function at which Hélène and Popaul first got to know one another.

Functions, both social and physical, play a large part in the Chabrol bestiary. Village life is carefully and affectionately described: the wedding with its familiar figures, the drunk, the exhibitionist, the simpleton; the banal but unpatronisingly

Claude Chabrol: Elements of Crime

Le Beau Serge

Thu 3 Sep 21:00; Sun 20 Sep 15:15 (+ intro by academic Catherine Dousteyssier-Khoze)

La Rupture

Fri 4 Sep 18:10; Sat 19 Sep 12:20; Sat 3 Oct 12:10

À double tour

Web of Passion
Sat 5 Sep 14:30; Sat 19 Sep 14:50

The Third Lover

L'oeil du malin
Sat 5 Sep 18:20; Sat 19 Sep 20:45

The Beast Must Die

Que la bête meure
Sat 5 Sep 20:20; Thu 17 Sep 18:10 (+ intro by critic, lecturer and programmer Geoff Andrew);
Sun 4 Oct 18:10

Les Biches

Sun 6 Sep 18:30; Wed 23 Sep 20:40;
Sun 27 Sep 15:00; Mon 5 Oct 14:30

Juste avant la nuit

Just before Nightfall
Tue 8 Sep 20:45; Sun 27 Sep 12:10; Fri 2 Oct 14:30

Le Boucher

Wed 9 Sep 18:10 (+ intro by season curator Catherine Wheatley); Mon 21 Sep 20:50;
Fri 25 Sep 20:45; Sun 4 Oct 12:20; Tue 6 Oct 14:30

Philosophical Screens: Le Boucher

Wed 9 Sep 20:10 Blue Room

Wedding in Blood

Les noces rouges
Thu 10 Sep 18:10; Tue 15 Sep 21:00;
Tue 29 Sep 18:20

Ten Days' Wonder

La décade prodigieuse
Thu 10 Sep 20:30 (+ intro by season curator Catherine Wheatley); Sat 19 Sep 18:10

La Femme infidèle

The Unfaithful Wife
From Fri 11 Sep (Preview screening on Tue 1 Sep 20:30)

Violette Nozière

Sun 20 Sep 18:00 (+ intro by academic Catherine Dousteyssier-Khoze); Wed 30 Sep 20:30

The Hatter's Ghost

Les fantômes du chapelier
Tue 22 Sep 18:00; Mon 28 Sep 20:35

The Cry of the Owl

Le cri du hibou
Tue 22 Sep 20:55; Mon 28 Sep 18:00

Mean Girls: Claude Chabrol's Dangerous Women

Wed 23 Sep 18:15

The Swindle

Rien ne va plus
Fri 25 Sep 18:15; Sat 3 Oct 18:15 (+ intro by Claude Chabrol's daughter and collaborator Cécile Maistre-Chabrol)

The Colour of Lies

Au coeur du mensonge
Sat 26 Sep 15:00; Sun 4 Oct 15:10

Story of Women

Une affaire de femmes
Sat 26 Sep 17:50; Thu 1 Oct 20:30

La Cérémonie

Thu 1 Oct 18:00 (+ extended intro on queer Chabrol by academic Kit Francis Bradbury Rance);
Tue 6 Oct 20:45

The Bridesmaid

La demoiselle d'honneur
Sat 3 Oct 15:10; Mon 5 Oct 20:40 (+ intro by season curator Catherine Wheatley)

The Girl Cut in Two

La fille coupée en deux
Sat 3 Oct 20:40; Tue 6 Oct 18:00 (+ Q&A with Claude Chabrol's daughter and collaborator Cécile Maistre-Chabrol)

With thanks to

Tamasa Distribution

The BFI will be releasing a selection of Claude Chabrol's films on Blu-ray and DVD in 2027

observed speeches; the gossip in the butcher's shop where an elderly man distinguishes between war and murder; the funeral procession and the graveside ritual.

The sense of history is strong too. Starting in the present the film works backwards to reveal links with the past. Mlle Hélène has been three years at the school; it is ten years since her unhappy affair; Popaul had been 15 years in the army – Algeria, Indo-China. Hélène rehearses Popaul and the children in a formal 18th-century dance for which she manages to get Popaul to dress up – though she characteristically remains in modern clothes. Finally she leads us back to the origins: a tour through the subterranean haunts of our primitive ancestors. It is at this point that the killings begin.

And then of course Chabrol's favourite ritual, eating. It's part of his witty humanism that he loves revelations at the table. Not a film is without some central eating scene. Here we open with the wedding banquet. The butcher is asked to carve the exquisite but 'bleu' hunk of beef. Hélène laughs at his professional pride. Does she like beef, he suddenly asks her, as they walk back later to the schoolhouse. He is obsessed by blood, and his obsession, we are to learn, only leaves him in her presence. But Popaul is not all beast himself. His affection for Hélène is genuine. He is respectable – boorish maybe, but eager to please. He brings Hélène a gift of bottled cherries and thumps the jar down on her books. But it's a gift tenderly meant. Hélène by now suspects him. While he eats the cherries out of mere appetite and willingness to consolidate their togetherness, she eats compulsively in an effort to keep horror at bay by this trivial and commonplace action. Popaul's banalities are less a measure of his character than an effort to hide his passion for her.

Hélène knows of his guilt but cannot divine that the reason for it is herself. It is night. As she would not once give in to his loving assault, so now she barricades in vain the doors and windows of the schoolhouse against his lethal attack. When he has told her everything, she again rejects him by closing her eyes. He turns the knife on himself, persuaded that the beast must finally die. When she steps forward to help him her foot and leg glide between his splayed limbs in a tragic parody of the love she might have offered him. 'Embrassez-moi' are his last words to her; and now at last she does kiss him, acknowledging too late a lesson which, for a teacher, she was slow to learn. In obedience to Chabrol's conviction that appearances constantly belie the truth, the teacher it is who has turned butcher. This is a dazzling addition to the work of a filmmaker who must now rank among the world's best.

Gavin Millar, *Sight and Sound*, Winter 1970/1